TEXORA · COURSE NOTES · LECTURE SHEET

Characteristics of Business Letters

What makes a business letter good — the seven C's: completeness, conciseness, clarity, correctness, courtesy, consideration and concreteness, each with its failure mode.

HUM-1107 · COMMUNICATIVE ENGLISH · TOPIC 8 · LEVEL 1 TERM 1

1. The seven C's

A business letter is judged by results — did it get the reply, the order, the payment, the goodwill? The standard checklist of its qualities is the **seven C's**. Each is stated here with its meaning and the failure it prevents.

QUALITY	MEANING	FAILURE IT PREVENTS
Completeness	The letter contains everything the reader needs to understand and act — all questions answered, all facts (quantity, date, reference) present	The second letter: "Please also tell us…" — delay, cost, and an impression of carelessness
Conciseness	The message in the fewest words that carry it fully — short sentences, no padding phrases, no repetition	The reader's time wasted and the point buried ("we beg to inform you that this is to inform you…")
Clarity	One meaning only: precise words, logical order, unambiguous references ("the 12th" of which month?)	Misread instructions and wrong goods shipped — ambiguity is the most expensive stylistic fault
Correctness	Facts, figures, names, grammar and spelling all right; the letter checked before dispatch	A wrong price honoured, a wrong date believed, a firm's credibility dented by careless English
Courtesy	Politeness of tone throughout — requests phrased as requests, complaints without abuse, thanks where thanks are due	Goodwill destroyed: even a justified claim written rudely loses its reader
Consideration	The "you-attitude": the letter written from the reader's angle — their benefit, their situation, their convenience	The self-centred letter ("we want, we need…") that gives the reader no reason to act

Concreteness	Specific facts and figures instead of vague generalities — “by 20 November” not “soon”; “3% shade variation” not “some problem”	Promises nobody can check and requests nobody can execute

2. The C’s at work: before and after

Weak: “We are in receipt of your letter and beg to state that the goods will be sent soon. We hope you will like them. We want early payment.”

Rewritten: “Thank you for your order No. 88 of 10 November 2026. The 500 kg of 30s carded yarn will be dispatched on 18 November and should reach you by 20 November. As agreed, payment is due within 30 days of the invoice date; the invoice is enclosed.”

The rewrite is complete (order, quantity, dates, terms), concise (three sentences doing the work of four), clear and concrete (every noun carries a number), correct (references checkable), courteous (“Thank you”) and considerate (it tells the reader what *they* receive and when). One short paragraph can satisfy all seven.

3. Supporting qualities

- **Promptness** — a good letter is also a timely one: replies within a working day or two, because a perfect letter sent late fails its business purpose (Topics 2 and 5 in action).
- **Coherence** — paragraphs in logical sequence, one idea each, linked so the reader never backtracks; clarity’s structural half.
- **Appropriate tone and appearance** — the letter looks like its content: neat layout (Topic 7), language matched to the relationship — formal to a ministry, businesslike-warm to a regular buyer, never familiar where familiarity has not been earned.

4. Glossary — key terms of this topic

TERM	MEANING
The seven C’s	Completeness, conciseness, clarity, correctness, courtesy, consideration, concreteness — the checklist of a good business letter.
You-attitude	Writing from the reader’s point of view; the substance of consideration.
Concreteness	The use of specific facts, figures and dates in place of vague general statements.
Coherence	The logical connection and ordering of a letter’s parts.

Padding	Wordy, empty phrases (“we beg to state that”) that lengthen without informing.

5. Key points and summary

- The seven C’s are the examinable standard: complete, concise, clear, correct, courteous, considerate, concrete.
- Each C guards against a named business failure — the second letter, the misread instruction, the dishonoured price, the lost goodwill.
- Promptness, coherence and fit appearance complete the portrait; the before/after rewrite of §2 is the model to imitate.

6. Practice

Answer in your own words; brief model answers follow.

1. List the seven C’s and attach to each the failure it prevents, in one phrase each.
2. Rewrite for conciseness: “I am writing this letter in order to inform you that our office will be closed on the occasion of the public holiday falling on Friday next.” (Keep the information; target under 15 words.)
3. Rewrite for consideration (you-attitude): “We cannot deliver your order until you send us the outstanding payment.”
4. Rewrite for concreteness: “Your fabric has some quality problems and we will look into it soon.”
5. A letter quotes a price of Tk 450 per kg where the agreed price was Tk 540, and the buyer holds the firm to the letter. Which C failed, and what checking habit prevents it?
6. Courtesy under provocation: draft the opening two sentences of a claim letter about a badly delayed shipment — firm, specific, and courteous.
7. Why do completeness and conciseness not contradict each other?

Answer key

1. Completeness — the follow-up letter; conciseness — the buried point; clarity — the misread instruction; correctness — the honoured error; courtesy — lost goodwill; consideration — the unanswered self-centred plea; concreteness — the unexecutable request.
2. Example: “Our office will be closed on Friday, [date], for the public holiday.” (12 words — all facts kept, all padding gone.)
3. “So that we can release your order for immediate delivery, could you please arrange the outstanding payment of Tk [amount] this week?” — the reader’s benefit (immediate delivery) leads; the requirement stays exact.

4. “Our inspection of Lot 12 found shade variation above the agreed 3% in 40 of 200 pieces. We will send our quality team’s full report by Thursday, 19 November, and propose a joint inspection on 22 November.”
5. Correctness. Habit: verify every figure in a letter against its source document (order, price list) before signing — letters bind the firm to what they say.
6. Example: “We refer to our order No. 41 of 28 October, due for delivery on 5 November and still not received on 12 November. We should be grateful for your immediate advice of the revised delivery date, as our production is being held up.” — firm (dates, consequences), specific, and courteous (no abuse, a request not a threat).
7. Completeness counts *content* (all needed facts present), conciseness counts *words* (no fact padded or repeated). A letter is complete in substance and concise in expression at once — the C’s constrain different dimensions.
